

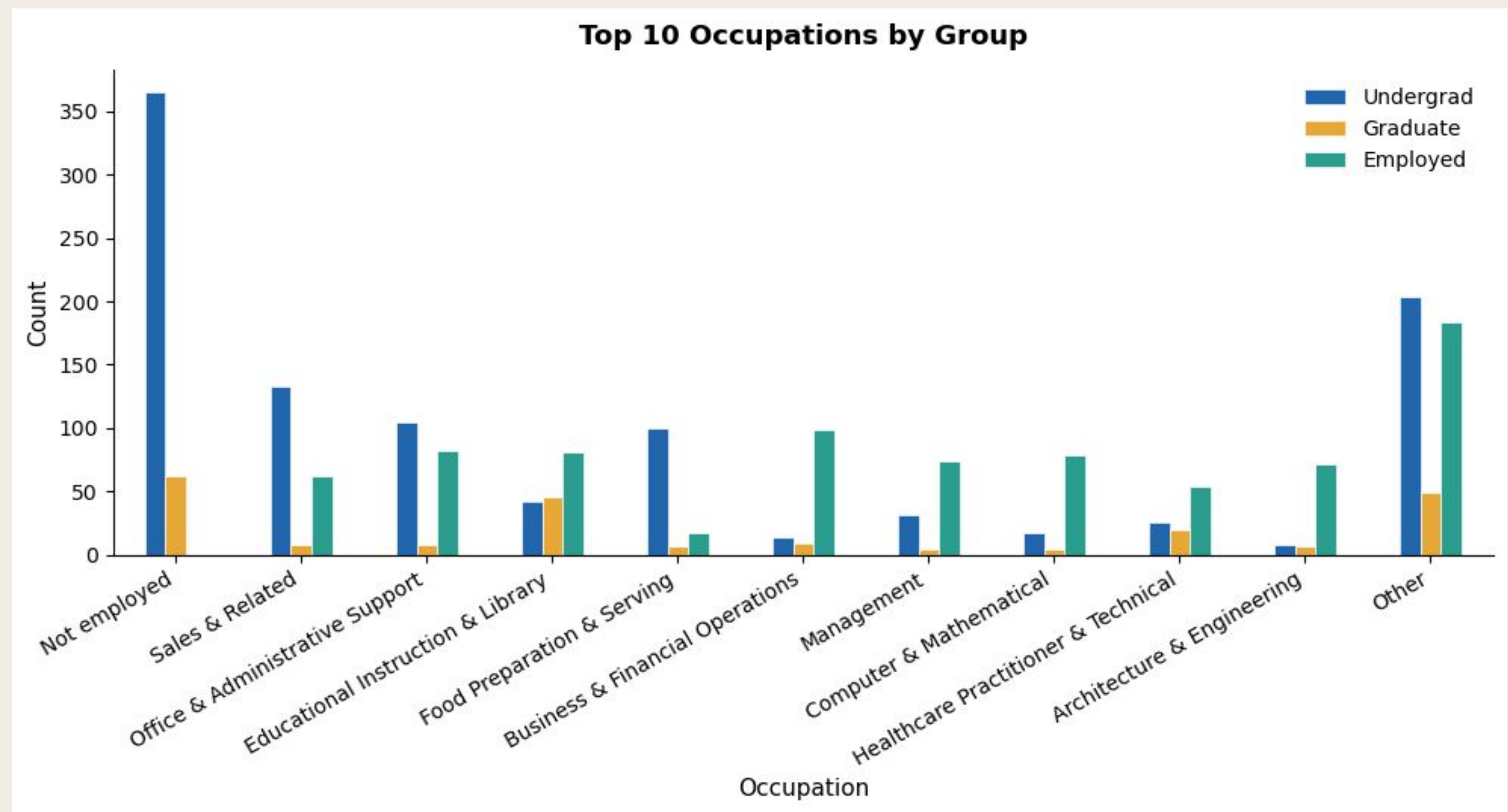
What distinguishes the ways undergrads, graduate students, and employed new-grads spend their time?

Alisha Li – Spring 2026 Data Science Capstone

Background & Motivation

Lifestyle is a key factor in undergrads’ decisions on what to pursue after college. While prior research primarily examines one group at a time, little work has been done comparing between them. This study aims to see if there are broad differences across educated young adults which may prompt future investigations.

About the data

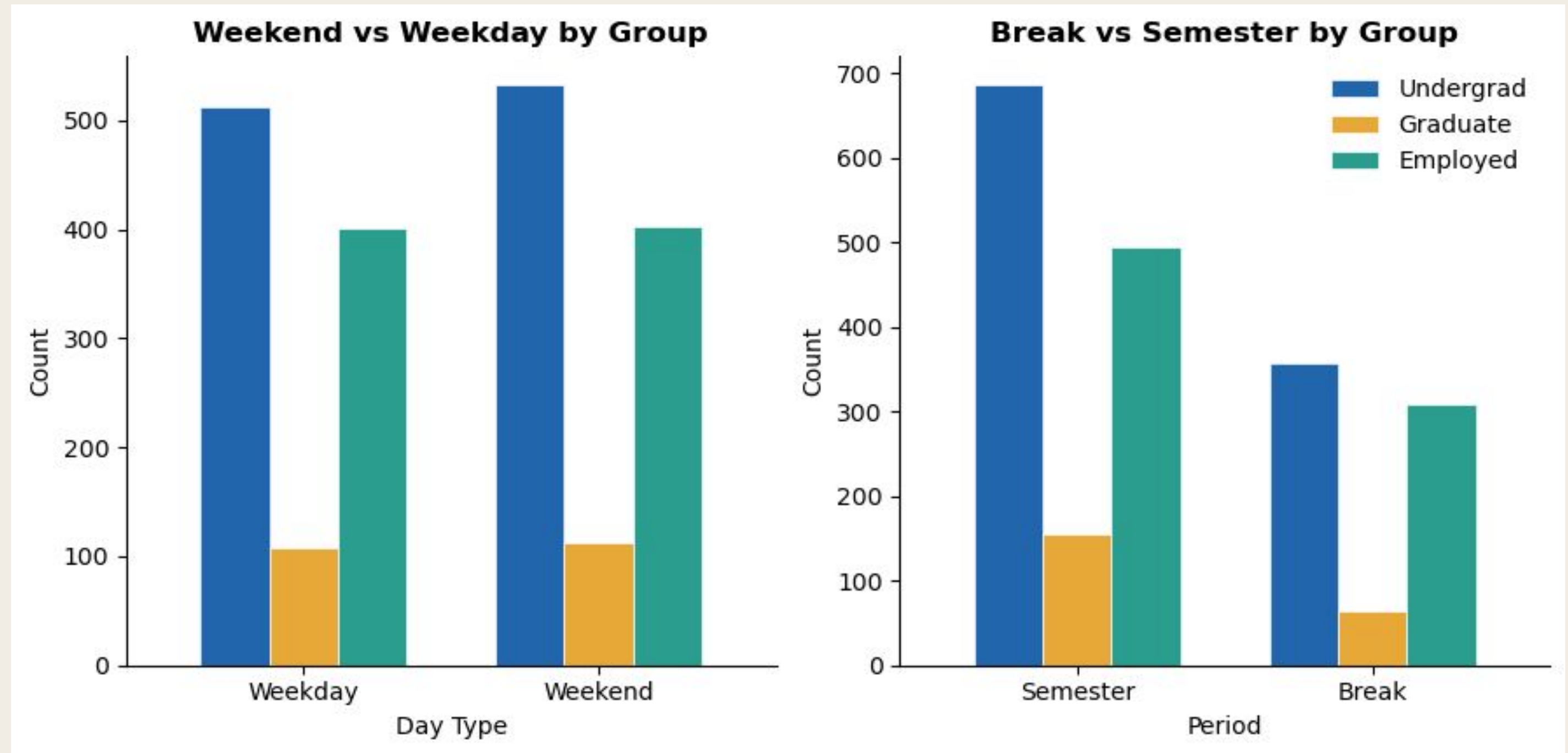


American Time Use Survey

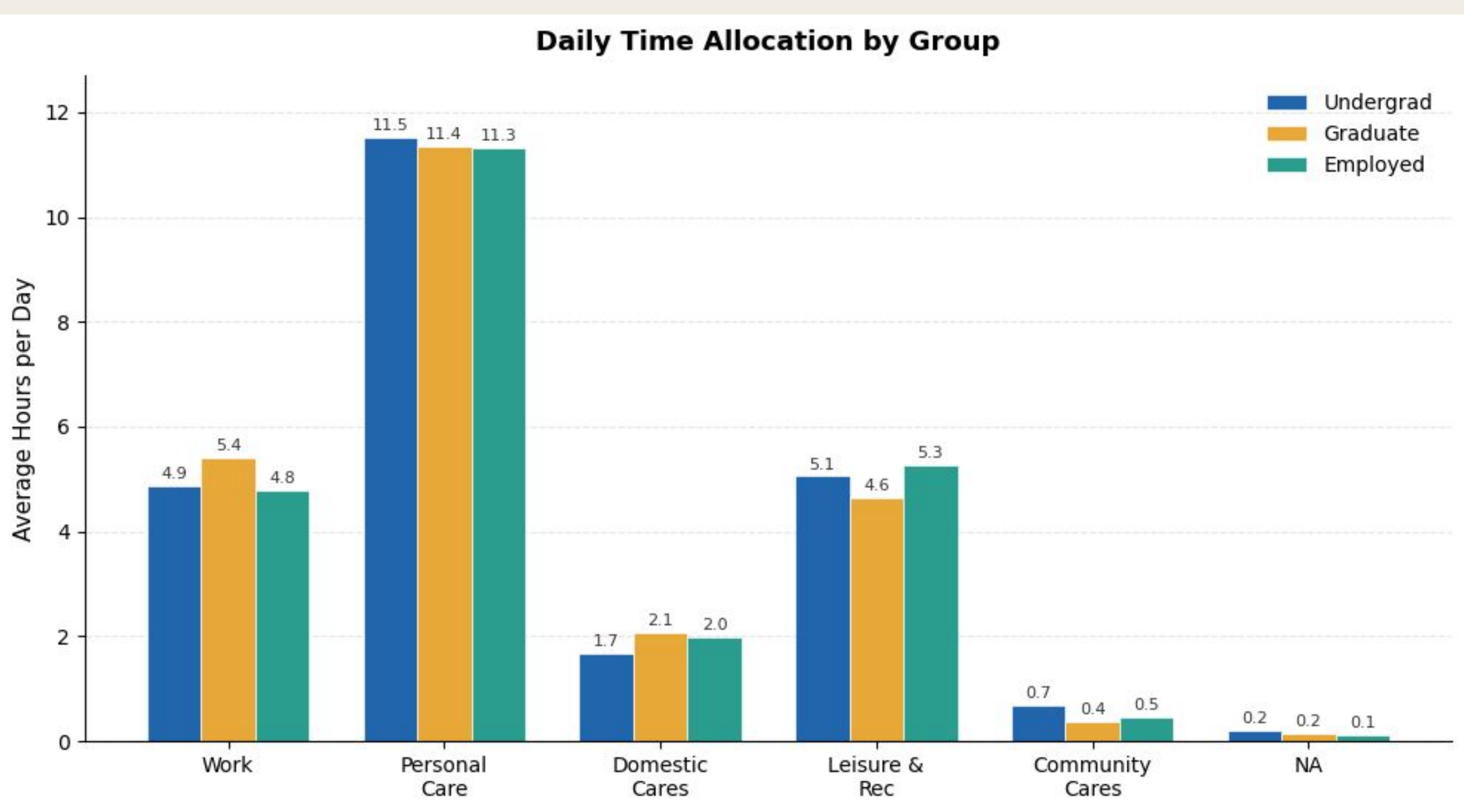
- Participants recall how their spent their prior day from 4am to 4am
- 2015-19, 2023-24
- Ages 19-26

Final Dataset

- 2067 respondents
 - 1044 Undergrad (no bachelors, enrolled),
 - 803 Employed New-Grad (bachelors, not enrolled, employed)
 - 220 Graduate (bachelors, enrolled)
- 4 background variables: sex, year, weekend, break
- 6 activity buckets: work (educational or employment), personal care, domestic cares, leisure/rec, community cares, NA

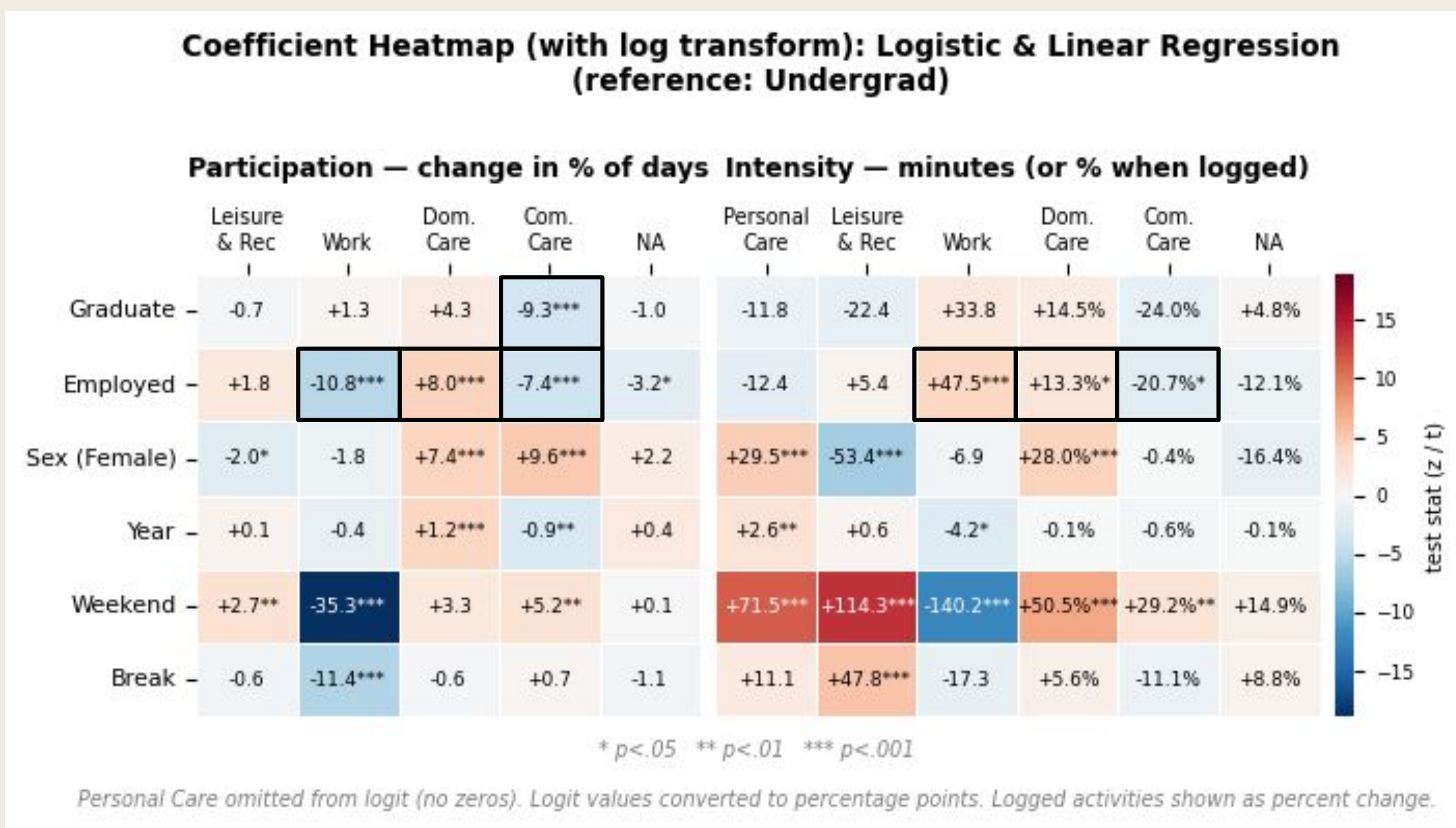


Exploratory Data Analysis

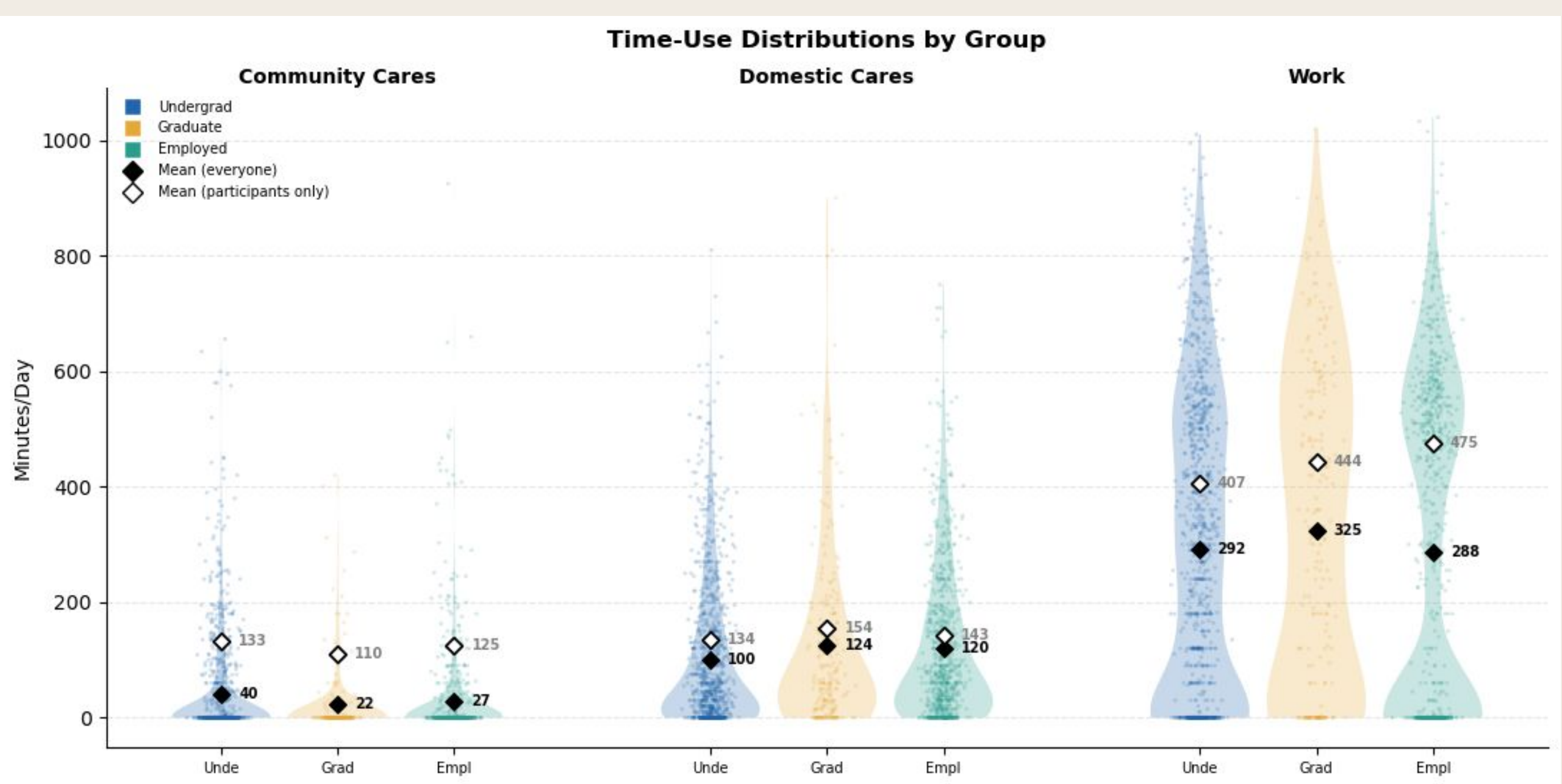


Methodology

- 2 multinomial logistic regressions comparing group on background vs group on background + activities
 - Likelihood Ratio Test showed adding activities do improve group prediction
- | Model | Log-Likelihood | AIC |
|-----------------|----------------|---------|
| Background only | -1945.46 | 3910.92 |
| With Activites | -1922.06 | 3888.12 |
- p-value < .01
- Final Models:** 6 logistic (to address 0 inflation) + linear regression, one pair for each activity bucket regressed on group + background
 - a. Log transformed domestic, community, NA buckets



Results & Discussion



Daily time use differs most across domestic cares, community cares and work. Undergrads differ more from employed new grads.

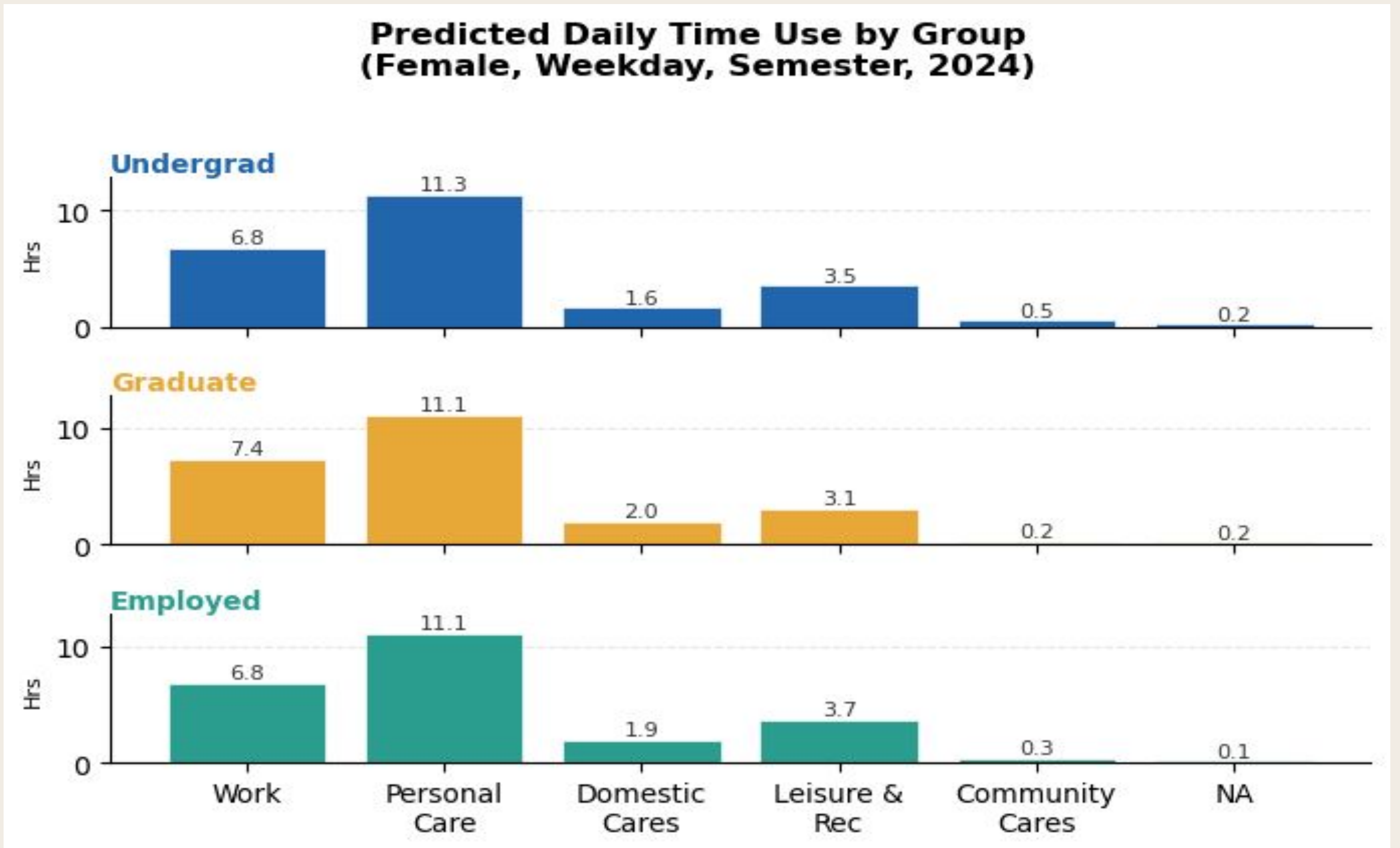
- Domestic care: 8 percentage points (pp) more likely – employed, 13% more min – employed
- Community care: 9pp less likely – grad, 7pp less likely – employed, 21% less min – employed
- Work: 11pp less likely – employed, 47 more min – employed

Limitations:

- Time tracking accuracy from recollection is questionable
- Does not consider different academia fields
- R² was low across all activities (.0015 - .12)

Future Work:

- Building better time tracking systems
- Investigating differences between fields (i.e. are medical students the one dragging leisure & rec down?)



Acknowledgements: Thanks to Professor Pattanayak and students in the spring 2026 DS Capstone Course for feedback throughout the semester.

References: 1. Bureau of Labor Statistics, U.S. Department of Labor. American Time Use Survey, 2015–2019, 2023–2024. <https://www.bls.gov/tus/>